

St. Paisios practical advice on a consistent daily prayer rule.

Here are his key teachings on this subject:

1. Start Small and Be Realistic

“Don’t try to do too much at once. If you take on more than you can handle, you’ll get discouraged and abandon prayer altogether. Begin with a little but do it with love.” *

“It’s better to say just the ‘Our Father’ with attention than to rush through many prayers while distracted.” *

*Spiritual Counsels Vol. 1: With Pain and Love for Modern Man

2. Consistency Over Quantity

“Prayer is like a small flame—if you keep adding wood little by little, it grows. But if you dump too much at once, you’ll smother it.” *

“Even if you can only pray for five minutes, do it every day without fail. God sees your effort.” *

*Spiritual Counsels Vol. 3: Spiritual Struggle

3. Don’t Be Scrupulous About Failures

“If you miss your prayer rule, don’t despair. The devil wants you to either become proud when you keep it or give up when you don’t. Just repent and start again.” *

“God doesn’t keep a ledger like an accountant; He looks at your heart.” *

Sayings of Elder Paisios (oral tradition)

4. Turn Daily Tasks into Prayer

“When you’re working, say the Jesus Prayer quietly. When you’re walking, bless the road with a prayer. Turn your whole life into a prayer.” *

“A mother changing diapers can pray more pleasingly than a monk in his cell if her heart is with God.” *

*Spiritual Counsels Vol. 4: Family Life

5. Struggle Against Distractions

“When your mind wanders, gently bring it back—like training a puppy. Don’t get angry at yourself; this is the struggle.” *

“Distractions are like flies—if you ignore them, they’ll leave. If you fight them, they’ll bother you more.” *

*Spiritual Counsels Vol. 3: Spiritual Struggle

6. Let Prayer Flow from Love, Not Obligation

“Prayer should be like a child talking to its father, not like a slave reporting to a master.” *

“If you pray only out of duty, it becomes dry. But if you pray out of love, even a little is enough.” *

*Elder Paisios of Mount Athos: Epistles

7. Seek Help from the Saints

“Ask the Theotokos and your patron saint to help you pray. They will support you when you’re weak.” *

“The saints struggled with prayer too—ask for their intercession, and they’ll teach you.” *

*Oral teachings (recorded in "Words of Life")

St. Paisios advised **gentle persistence**—focusing on quality over quantity, turning failures into humility, and integrating prayer into daily life. His approach was **flexible yet disciplined**, always rooted in **trust in God’s love**.